



## TV NEWS

DELHI



From staid newsreaders who followed the script to breathless anchors who air their opinions and interrogate their guests, living rooms are alive with the shrill sound of breaking news and clashing views

■ By Priya Sahgal

Once upon a time, television was Doordarshan. Staid faces with grave voices and painted lips read out government press releases in either proper English or chaste Hindi. Television legend has it that the only time Salma Sultan (also known as the anchor always with a rose in her hair) broke her deadpan expression was when she shed a tear while reading the news of Indira Gandhi's assassination. That was then. And then was not too long ago. It's been a little over a decade since private news channels debuted in India. Since then the stoic and the seated have given way to the young and the restless. Today's anchors don't read news; they emote it—in shrill, authoritative tones. There is little time for gravitas with news breaks every minute and anchors adlibbing analysis rather than reading from the safety of their teleprompters. On most channels, anchors are no longer mere newsreaders but journalists who sometimes interpret news instead of just reading it.

Each bulletin has the hype of a miniature Bollywood production. The mascara and powdered face drill has been extended to include hair stylists and fashion consultants. One private channel has banned men from sporting facial hair onscreen. Another wants all

women anchors to sport ironed hair. So much for the nostalgia of a Tejeswar Singh or a Pratima Puri, star news readers in the Doordarshan era. The setting is no longer a bland backdrop now, but a vital and interactive part of the news presentation. High-end virtual graphic systems feed three-dimensional images on the sets, changing the backdrop to suit the programme's mood. It's impossible to miss the flashing sign at the bottom of the screen that screams Breaking News. Because if it's not breaking, it's not news anymore.

The very definition of news has changed. During the era of state-controlled television, the only snakes who used to make it to the news were the ones in the cabinet. Now it seems a free-for-all—with snakes of the amphibious variety chasing boys, cars without drivers, suicide attempts that aren't—are finding space in primetime news bulletins. With every news channel repeating the same national news, there is pressure to look for the exotic. Tele-spin doctors say that these gimmicks get more viewers. It is a market that is growing. Today, the ad revenue for Hindi news channels averages over a Rs 1,000 crore annually. There are 23 national and 38 regional news channels in the market with four more national ones in the pipelines. We the People have been reduced to We the Eyeballs.

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